

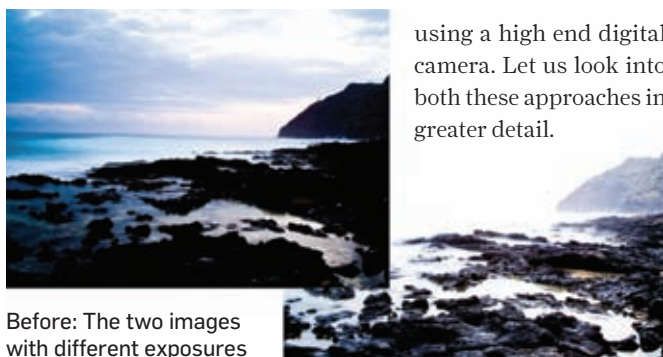
Adobe Photoshop: Blending Exposures

One major issue every serious photographer has to consider with nature or landscape photography is varying exposure and the lightest and darkest areas of an image.

But luckily with modern methods of HDR (high dynamic range) and the ability to take pictures with more than one exposure using modern digital cameras, it becomes very easy to blend images taken with varying exposures together into one single image with the right contrast. This also allows the image to more accurately portray the wide range of intensity levels found in real scenes, may it be with bright sunlight or faint sunlight. Another way



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Before: The two images with different exposures

using a high end digital camera. Let us look into both these approaches in greater detail.

of doing the same would be by applying different settings for processing the RAW file taken

Different Exposures

To illustrate this method we shall consider a scene where



After – The final image which is a result of blending in the two images

different regions are exposed to varying intensities of sunlight. First we have to obtain different images of the same scene, so that each part of the scene has a good exposure in at least one

of the images taken. It is best to take the images after setting the camera on a tripod or in a perfectly stationary position. For this example, we have taken two photos of the scene with a shutter speed of 13 seconds and 25 seconds, respectively.

In the 13-second exposure image, the sky and most of the ocean looks good, while rocks are darkened because of the shadows. On the other hand, the image with the 25-second exposure presents a good amount of detail in the dark foreground colours of the rocks that make the sky and water extremely bright and practically invisible.

Getting started in Photoshop

With the two images in hand, let us move on to Photoshop to blend in both the images to get our final image. Open both the images in Photoshop and copy one of the images into the file containing the other image.



Shutter Speed - 25 sec @ f/16 100 ISO

25 second exposure at f/16 and 100 ISO



Shutter Speed - 13 sec @ f/16 100 ISO

13 second exposure at f/16 and 100 ISO